

key-loggers to trap passwords or transfer files from your hard disk.

The name Trojan harks back to the famous Trojan War, in which the Greeks successfully invaded Troy by hiding some of their soldiers in a huge wooden horse. In computer lingo, a Trojan is a malicious security-violating program, which claims to do something useful but in reality is intentionally programmed to cause destruction to a computer without the user's knowledge. Trojans are executable programs, which automatically run themselves when opened and perform a function that they are programmed to do. These executable files usually have file extensions such as .exe, .vbs, .com, .scr, .bat or .js.

Trojans can spread in the guise of just about anything. They could reach you in the form of a screensaver, a picture file, a Flash greeting card or even games. IRC (Internet Relay Chat) channels and P2P programs such as Gnutella are a major source for spreading Trojans. A person can also specifically target you by sending a Trojan or a Web link with a Trojan activator embedded in the page script through e-mail.

So are Trojans more harmful than viruses? Well, Trojans do cause more damage as they can steal your password and mail it to the sender. And more

importantly, they allow hackers to gain complete control over your computer and perform actions such as DoS (Denial of Service) attacks. Hackers break into computers by using a Trojan horse and take advantage of human carelessness to steal your passwords and other confidential information.

Similar to Trojans is something called a Logic Bomb. These are programs that lie dormant until a certain event triggers them to perform a pre-programmed action. They are often used as a tool of revenge. For example, a student who has fared miserably in his examinations could program a Logic Bomb, which when triggered, could wipe out all the data stored by his college server.

Some popular Trojans are BackOrifice, Netbus, Sub7, The Thing, Spyman and Girl-

friend. Most of these are used as stealth spy tools. There are milder versions for playing pranks too.

Declaring war

When your PC is under a virus or Trojan attack, your anti-virus software plays hero. These tools are mostly 'search and destroy' tools that scan your hard drive for viruses and disinfect or remove the infected files. Over time, anti-virus tools have evolved to prevent virus infection by continuously running in the background and keeping a lookout for virus signatures in any files being read from almost any medium, be it the network, the Internet, or a floppy. On detecting a malicious code, they immediately alert the user.

As viruses get advanced, they rely more and more on system repositories such as registry entries and configuration files while using the network connections to spread. This in turn calls for the anti-virus software to expand and be able to detect and clean these infections as well. Most anti-virus software today are capable of doing this since this is very essential in case of new Trojans and worms, and the more advanced script-based viruses.

An anti-virus program works a lot like a text editor, except that instead of ASCII/ANSI text, it edits hex code (which is a way to display data using characters instead of binary code). The anti-virus

Removing a Trojan

Trojan attacks allow hackers to control another computer, read the person's hard drive and acquire personal information such as passwords and bank account details or worse, erase data from the hard disk. Be wary of receiving these malicious programs on IRC

channels or via e-mail in the form of a screensaver, game or a hack. Though today's anti-virus software have become sophisticated and efficient enough to handle Trojans, none of them can guarantee you complete protection.

The following signs indicate that your machine is infected with a Trojan:

- An unknown program running in the background
- An error message pops up either on start up or while running programs
- Random application crashes
- Extremely slow Internet connection speed in spite of your settings being appropriate
- Extremely slow start up

A Trojan is a program and it needs to start up when your machine boots.

Once you are sure you have a Trojan on your machine, you should look for any unusual programs in your startup settings. In Windows 98, you can use the system configuration tool (msconfig) to check for these, and the services manager in Win NT/2K. Once you have identified the stray program, remove it from the startup and reboot your machine. Now delete the program that was starting up and you've removed the Trojan.

Although it seems like an easy task, figuring out which program is a Trojan amongst a dozen or so entries can be a real pain. Instead, it would be better to use a software such as 'Cleaner' or other Trojan removal tools which scan systems for Trojans, stop them from activating, and then remove them from the infected system.

For more information about Trojans, visit:

www.moosoft.com, The Cleaner;
www.sniff-em.com, Purgeit!



What to Look for in Anti-virus Software



- Weekly updates to free virus definitions made available on the Internet
- Integration with

your e-mail client so that each e-mail gets scanned for viruses, Trojans and harmful scripts

- Automatic scanning of every file you execute to minimise chances of infection
- Scheduling of scans so you needn't worry about your weekly checkup
- The ability to create a Rescue disk which will come in handy if you aren't able to get Windows to boot
- Integration with Windows Explorer will allow you to quickly scan a suspicious file